

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS
MODULE 3
INDIA-PAKISTAN RELATIONS

Pakistan is India's northwestern neighbour, sharing a border with Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Rajasthan and Gujarat. The relationship has been bitter since independence. India and Pakistan are referred to as 'Conjugal twins' and often known as 'Brother Enemy.' The India-Pakistan boundary is the result of partition in 1947 under the **Radcliffe Award** - it starts from the marshy Rann of Kutch in Gujarat, traverses through the sandy deserts of Rajasthan, the fertile plains of Punjab and the mountains of Jammu and Kashmir up to the Karakoram range. The relations have often been afflicted by **cross-border terrorism, ceasefire violations, territorial disputes** etc.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

India-Pakistan relations are rooted in the colonial period, shaped by political, religious and socio-economic factors. The British 'divide and rule' policy exacerbated Hindu-Muslim communal tensions. The All-India Muslim League, under Muhammad Ali Jinnah, demanded a separate homeland for Muslims. The **Partition of 1947** led to massive violence, displacement of over 14 million people, and deep-seated mistrust, setting the stage for enduring bilateral tensions.

Major Wars Between India and Pakistan

War	Outcome
First Kashmir War (1947-48)	A UN-mediated ceasefire established the Line of Control (LoC). International boundary dispute left pending.
Second Kashmir War (1965)	Tashkent Agreement (1966). Thousands of lives lost; USA and USSR intervention required.
Bangladesh Liberation War (1971)	Creation of Bangladesh. Shimla Agreement (1972) with Pakistan.
Kargil War (1999)	Pakistani troops infiltrated Kargil district across LoC. India reclaimed Tiger Hills and other strategic peaks in Batalik.

Key Developments Post-2021

Event	Significance
LoC Ceasefire Reaffirmation (2021)	Both countries reaffirmed the 2003 LoC ceasefire. Attempt to de-escalate tensions after sporadic border incidents.
Pahalgam Attack (2025)	A terrorist attack killed 26 civilians. India blamed Pakistan-based groups.

Operation Sindoor (2025)	India struck nine alleged terrorist infrastructure sites across LoC. Dismantling of Pakistan-based terror networks including JeM and Hizbul Mujahideen.
Temporary Ceasefire (2025)	International mediation facilitated a ceasefire. Highlights fragility of peace, escalation risks and nuclear deterrence considerations.
IWT Suspension (2025)	India suspended its participation in the Indus Waters Treaty citing national security concerns.

POLITICAL RELATIONS

The political and diplomatic relations of the two countries have seen enormous ups and downs. On one hand, after the General Elections to the 16th Lok Sabha, the PM-designate invited PM Nawaz Sharif and other SAARC leaders to attend the swearing-in of the new Union Council of Ministers in New Delhi. On the other hand, due to an escalation in ceasefire violations by Pakistan across the Line of Control, all the visits including the SAARC Summit were cancelled and boycotted.

ECONOMIC AND COMMERCIAL RELATIONS

India and Pakistan have curtailed formal trade. South Asia is the **least economically integrated region** in the world, with only **5% of its trade conducted internally**. Bilateral trade has seen a significant drop in recent years. There is an informal bilateral trade of around **\$10 billion**, with most of the goods imported by Pakistan.

Key Trade Items

Export	Main Items
India exports to Pakistan	Cotton, organic chemicals, machinery, food products including prepared animal fodder, vegetables, plastic articles, man-made filament, coffee, tea and spices, dyes, oil seeds, etc.
India imports from Pakistan	Copper and copper articles, fruits and nuts, cotton, salt, sulphur and earths and stones, organic chemicals, mineral fuels, rubber, plastic products, wool, etc.

Key Trade Developments

- MFN status was accorded to Pakistan in **1996** as per India's commitments as a WTO member. Pakistan has not reciprocated.
- Post **Pulwama attack (2019)**: India withdrew MFN status and hiked customs duty on exports from Pakistan to **200%**. Pakistan subsequently suspended bilateral trade.
- Post **Pahalgam attack (April 2025)**: India enforced a comprehensive ban on the import and transit of goods from Pakistan, suspending all bilateral trade.
- According to CAIT, trade that was close to **USD 3 billion in 2018** declined to approximately **USD 1.2 billion by 2024**.

SECURITY RELATIONS

While security concerns remain the most contentious aspect of India-Pakistan relations, there have been limited cooperative mechanisms aimed at crisis management and conflict prevention. CBMs such as **hotline communications between military commanders**, joint statements on ceasefire and informal Track-II dialogues on counter-terrorism highlight attempts to reduce

escalation risks. Despite these efforts, the persistent **Kashmir dispute, cross-border terrorism and nuclear deterrence dynamics** often overshadow these initiatives.

People to People Contacts

- The revised **Visa Agreement (September 2012)** liberalized the existing bilateral visa regime. Introduced 'Visa on Arrival' at Attari/Wagah border for nationals above 65 years and 'Group Tourist Visa.'
- In November 2018, the groundbreaking ceremony of the **Kartarpur Corridor** was held - a visa-free corridor for Indian Sikh pilgrims to visit Gurdwara Kartarpur Sahib in Pakistan.
- Cultural and people-to-people exchanges: cross-border pilgrimages, student exchange programmes, joint film festivals and sporting encounters.

ENVIRONMENTAL AND WATER COOPERATION

Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), 1960

The issue of water sharing was initially sorted out by the **Inter-Dominion accord of May 4, 1948**. Eventually in 1960, the two countries reached a decisive step with the intervention of the World Bank. The IWT was **signed by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and President of Pakistan Ayub Khan** and marked out control over the six rivers running across the Indus basin.

Allocation	Rivers	India's Rights
Pakistan - Western Rivers	Jhelum, Chenab, Indus	India can use for consumption purposes; restrictions placed on building storage systems.
India - Eastern Rivers	Ravi, Beas, Sutlej	Full control and unrestricted use.

India has about 20% of the total water carried by the Indus system while **Pakistan has 80%**. Pakistan gets 80% of the water in the 6-river Indus system; this is 90 times greater than Mexico's share under a 1944 pact with the US. It is Asia's only treaty with specific water-sharing formulas on cross-border flows.

Current IWT Disputes

Project	River	Pakistan's Objection
Kishanganga Project (330 MW)	Jhelum tributary	Pakistan claims it will result in 40% reduction of water flow and flouted provisions of the IWT.
Ratle Project (850 MW)	Chenab	Pakistan wants the storage capacity to be reduced from 24 million cubic metres to 8 million cubic metres.

Suspension of Indus Waters Treaty (April 2025)

- On **April 23, 2025**, India announced the suspension of its participation in the treaty, citing national security concerns following the Pahalgam terrorist attack.
- **Immediate Actions by India:** Halted flow of water from the Chenab River through the Baglihar Dam; conducted off-season reservoir flushing at Salal and Baglihar projects without prior notification to Pakistan.
- **Domestic Reallocation Plans:** Announced plans to divert water previously allocated to Pakistan for domestic use, particularly for states like Rajasthan.

- **Pakistan's Response:** Condemned India's actions, labelling them as an 'act of war.' Expressed concerns over potential humanitarian and economic impacts.
- **International Reactions:** The World Bank stated it would not intervene in the dispute, as its role was limited to facilitating the treaty.

CROSS-BORDER TERRORISM

Cross-border terrorism remains one of the **core and persistent issues** in India-Pakistan relations. India has consistently highlighted that territory under Pakistan's control is being used to plan, finance and execute terrorist attacks against India. Internationally designated terrorist organisations such as **Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT)**, **Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM)** and their affiliates continue to operate from Pakistan.

Notable Terrorist Incidents

Incident	Key Detail
Pathankot Airbase Attack (2016)	Around six terrorists in army attire attempted to storm the Pathankot airbase, linked to JeM.
Uri Attack (2016)	Four terrorists launched a suicide assault on an Army camp in Uri, killing 19 soldiers and injuring 30. One of the deadliest attacks on security forces in Kashmir in two decades.
Pahalgam Attack (2025)	A terrorist attack killed 26 civilians. India accused Pakistan-based groups of orchestrating the attack.

Indian Counter-Terror Operations

Operation	Detail
Operation Sindoor (2025)	Indian forces targeted nine terrorist infrastructure sites across the LoC, aimed at dismantling JeM and Hizbul Mujahideen networks.
Operation Mahadev (2025)	India eliminated key members of The Resistance Front (TRF), an offshoot of LeT, responsible for recent attacks.

KASHMIR DISPUTE

Maharaja **Hari Singh, the maharaja of Kashmir**, signed the **Instrument of Accession** to the Indian Union in October 1947, following a revolution among his Muslim subjects along the western borders and the intervention of Pashtun tribesmen. This led to intervention by Pakistan (which considered the state a natural extension of Pakistan) and by India (which intended to confirm the act of accession).

The **Indo-Pakistan War of 1947** resulted from the Instrument of Accession. The war ended in December 1948, by which time the **Line of Control (LoC)** was established to demarcate the administrative segments of Kashmir. The 1965 war ended with the **Tashkent Agreement**. In 1999, the **Kargil War** reopened raw wounds; Pakistani troops infiltrated the Kargil district across the LoC. India retaliated and reclaimed Tiger Hills and other strategic peaks in Batalik.

In 1965, the USA and the erstwhile USSR had to intervene for the resolution. India recorded a victory but with damages to both nations.

India has always been willing to discuss all issues, including J&K, with Pakistan. Several rounds of bilateral discussions took place between the two countries over 1950-51, 1953-54, 1956-57 and 1962-63 to resolve differences over Kashmir. **Pakistan sponsored terrorists have terrorised the population** and hindered political dialogue by intimidating or silencing voices of moderation.

SIR CREEK

Sir Creek is a 96 km strip of water disputed between India and Pakistan in the Rann of Kutch marshlands. Originally named **Ban Ganga**, Sir Creek is named after a British representative. The creek opens up in the Arabian Sea and roughly divides the Kutch region of Gujarat from the Sindh Province of Pakistan.

Dispute

Pakistan claims the entire creek as per the **Bombay Government Resolution of 1914** signed between the Government of Sindh and Rao Maharaj of Kutch (setting the boundary as the eastern flank - the Green Line). India claims the boundary lies midchannel as depicted in a map drawn in 1925 and implemented by the installation of mid-channel pillars in 1924.

Importance of Sir Creek

- Apart from strategic location, Sir Creek's core importance is **fishing resources** - it is considered among the richest fishing grounds in Asia.
- Possible presence of great **oil and gas concentrations under the sea**, which are currently unexploited due to the impending deadlock.

SIACHEN GLACIER

The ceasefire line established at the end of the 1947-48 war **did not delineate beyond grid reference NJ9842**, which falls south of the Siachen glacier, to the Chinese border, but left it as 'Chalunka (on the Shyok River), Khor, thence North to the glaciers.'

Country	Interpretation of the Phrase 'Thence North to the Glaciers'	Current Position
Pakistan	The line should go from NJ 9842 straight to the Karakoram Pass on the Sino-Indian border.	India is the occupying party in Siachen and should unconditionally withdraw; the pre-1984 status quo should be restored.
India	The line should proceed north from NJ 9842 along the Salto Range to the border with China.	Joint demarcation of the Actual Ground Position Line (AGPL) on the ground should be the first step, followed by joint verification and redeployment.

CONFIDENCE BUILDING MEASURES (CBMs)

Since Partition, India and Pakistan have signed many agreements to generate confidence and reduce tensions. The most notable among them are: **Liaquat-Nehru Pact (1950)**, Indus Waters Treaty (1960), Tashkent Agreement (1966), Rann of Kutch Agreement (1969), Shimla Accord (1972), Salal Dam Agreement (1978) and the establishment of the Joint Commission.

Military CBMs

CBM	Detail
Agreement on Prohibition of Attack	India and Pakistan exchange lists of their nuclear installations annually (first exchange January 1, 1992) to prevent attacking each other's atomic facilities.

against Nuclear Installations (Signed 1988, ratified 1990)	
Agreement on Advance Notification on Military Exercises (1991)	Played a crucial role in de-escalating tensions on both sides of the LoC.
Communication Link (PMSA-Indian Coast Guard) (2005)	Established to facilitate early exchange of information regarding anglers apprehended for straying into each other's waters.
Hotline between DGMOs (Since 1965)	Used in an unscheduled exchange to discuss troop movements and allay tensions after the 26/11 attacks.

Non-Military CBMs

CBM	Status
Delhi-Lahore Bus Service (1999)	Suspended after 2001 Parliament Attack; resumed 2003; suspended again in 2019 after Article 370 abrogation.
Samjhauta Express (Post-Shimla Agreement)	Connects Lahore and Attari. Suspended 2019 after revocation of special status of Kashmir.
Weekly Bus Service (Srinagar-Muzaffarabad)	Has withstood the test of times till recently.
Kartarpur Corridor (2019)	Visa-free corridor for Indian Sikh pilgrims to visit Gurdwara Kartarpur Sahib in Pakistan.

OTHER ISSUES

Kulbhushan Jadhav Case

Pakistani authorities reportedly arrested Jadhav in what they termed a counter-intelligence operation in Mashkal, Balochistan on 3 March 2016. Pakistan alleged Jadhav is a R&AW 'spy'. India denied the charges and confirmed Jadhav was an Indian national and a retired naval officer. India rejected the validity of the alleged confession video. Pakistan repeatedly denied consular access, and with the death sentence of Jadhav, India moved to the International Court of Justice (ICJ). The ICJ ordered in May not to carry out Jadhav's execution, pending a final decision.

Other Key Issues Summary

Issue	Key Point
CPEC	The route passes through disputed Kashmir under illegal occupation by Pakistan. India opposes CPEC as it concerns sovereignty, internationalization of the Kashmir dispute, and growing Chinese influence in the Indian Ocean.
TAPI Pipeline	Trans-country natural gas pipeline from Turkmenistan to India through Afghanistan and Pakistan (~1,800 km). Faced with the challenge of terrorism - unless the pipeline is secured from the Taliban and militant groups operating in Pakistan, it is hard to see how the TAPI dream can go beyond the groundbreaking ceremony.
SAARC	Future increasingly questioned after cancellation of the summit scheduled for Islamabad in November 2016, following the Uri attack. SAARC Summits can be held only in the presence of all members.
Hafiz Saeed	India's demand to reinvestigate the 2008 case and put on trial Jamaat-ud-Dawa chief Hafiz Saeed has been negated by Pakistan demanding 'concrete' evidence.
MFN Status	MFN accorded to Pakistan in 1996 as per WTO commitment. Pakistan has not reciprocated, citing non-tariff barriers and a huge trade imbalance.

FUTURE MEASURES AND WAY FORWARD

- India and Pakistan should consider initiating an institutionalised, regular but discreet dialogue between **intelligence chiefs**.
- The **media** is playing a critical role in shaping popular perceptions. A continuing dialogue between journalists, editors and proprietors of media houses is needed.
- It is vital that **Track II dialogues** be encouraged by both New Delhi and Islamabad.
- A **stable, prosperous, sovereign and independent Afghanistan** is in the interest of India and Pakistan, and both countries must work for this goal.
- Attempts should be made to create a **visa-free regime** for important stakeholders including academics, journalists, businessmen, students, artists and former senior officials.
- Creating international pressure on Pakistan to curb state-sponsored terrorism. In June 2018, Pakistan was placed on the **FATF grey list** for failing to curb anti-terror financing. Such steps can increase the cost of using state-sponsored terrorism as a tool by Pakistan.

CONCLUSION

South Asia has not yet progressed despite having the potential to ensure fast-paced economic growth and development. This is mostly because of the differences and tensions between India and Pakistan. **Improved India-Pakistan relations can ensure the addressing of any threat the subcontinent may face in the future.** Cooperation and coexistence through trust can ensure the establishment of a peaceful and prosperous South Asia.

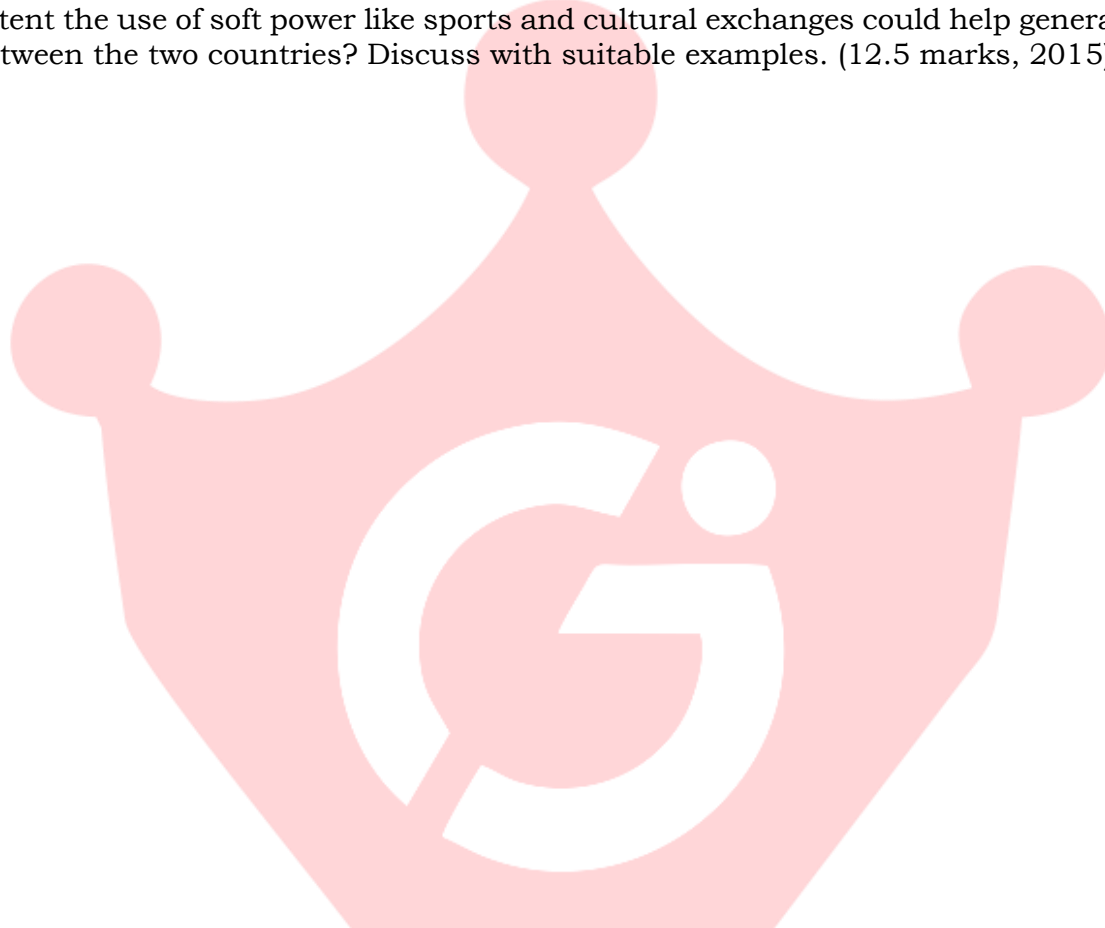
Way forward for India-Pakistan relations lies in **sustained dialogue, curbing cross-border terrorism, promoting soft diplomacy and trade cooperation:**

- **Sustained Dialogue:** Both countries need to engage in consistent and sincere dialogue at various levels, addressing core issues like terrorism, Kashmir and trade in a constructive manner.

- **Promoting Soft Diplomacy:** Promoting cultural and academic exchanges, sports diplomacy and tourism can build trust and reduce deep-seated animosities.
- **Economic Cooperation:** Expanding trade relations and economic ties could create a vested interest for both nations to maintain peaceful relations.
- **Confidence-Building Measures:** Enhancing military-to-military communication, such as hotlines and periodic meetings, can prevent misunderstandings and reduce chances of accidental escalation.

MAINS PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1. Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchanges could help generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples. (12.5 marks, 2015)



GALLANT IAS